

Report Name

Rwanda Development Board_Rwanda_2022-23_9-month Report

Fellowship Organization

Rwanda Development Board

Fellowship City

Kigali

Fellowship Country

Rwanda

Fellowship Start Date

2022-09-01

Fellowship End Date

2023-08-31

Your Fellowship Position and Workplace

What is your fellowship title/role?

Operations Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

Designing and implementing monitoring and evaluation frameworks

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

The organization ran a thorough onboarding over the first week. My supervisor walked me through existing projects and introduced me to the full team.

Describe a representative day at work.

Morning: review emails and prepare for meetings. 9am-12pm: attend team meetings and work on current projects. Lunch with colleagues. 1pm-5pm: focused project work and stakeholder calls. Evenings are generally free.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

45

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

1) Developed a comprehensive monitoring framework for the organization's flagship program. 2) Produced a strategic research report that has been shared with senior leadership and external partners.

What is your office environment like?

Open plan office with approximately 20-30 staff. Collaborative culture with strong emphasis on teamwork. Good facilities including reliable internet.

To whom do you report?

Director of Programs

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year.

- Strengthen my research and analytical writing capabilities - Expand my professional network in the African development sector - Develop fluency in the local language to a conversational level - Lead at least one independent project from design to completion - Build skills in organizational strategy and program design

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

No

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

My academic background and previous experience prepared me well for the core responsibilities. Some aspects of working in this specific context required adjustment and learning on the job.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I flew from my home country to Kigali via a connection. The organization provided information about the journey in advance.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

Work Permit Category A

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

Rwanda Development Board online portal

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

After arriving

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

USD 100 covered by organization

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

Covered by the organization

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Rwanda has the most straightforward process, apply online and it takes 2 weeks

How was your arrival and first week in your host country?

Arrival was smooth. The organization arranged transport from the airport. The first week was overwhelming in a positive way with so much new information and people to meet.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Fully provided by organization in a staff house near the office.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Urban

Please describe your living environment

Clean modern house with reliable electricity and water. Very safe area.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

Kigali is very organized. I use moto-taxis for short trips and Uber for longer distances. The city is very safe to walk.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

The weather in Rwanda varies throughout the year. Currently in a warm season with occasional rain.

What are the local languages in your community?

The main local languages plus English which is widely used in professional settings.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

Smart casual for work. Outside work, standard casual clothing is appropriate. Modest dress is advisable in more traditional settings.

How have you been spending your free time?

Gorilla trekking was life changing. Weekend trips to Lake Kivu. Kigali has excellent restaurants and a growing arts scene.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

I stay connected with family and friends through regular video calls. Socially I have built good relationships with colleagues and other fellows in the area.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Yes

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

Kigali is one of the safest cities in Africa. I walk freely at night without concern. Crime is very low.

What has been your experience with crime so far?

I have not experienced any crime directly. I maintain awareness of my surroundings and follow local advice about safe practices.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town.

Kigali has a manageable security situation for those who take appropriate precautions. I feel comfortable in my daily movements.

Monthly Budget

Rent

0 RWF

Transportation

30000 RWF

Groceries

40000 RWF

Eating Out

50000 RWF

Entertainment

30000 RWF

Other

20000 RWF

Reflections and Feedback

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals?

I am making good progress on all of my goals. The goal around building local professional relationships has been the most fulfilling. I am on track overall.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

Minor frustrations around missing family and friends was hardest. Overall very satisfied with the experience.

How have you dealt with culture shock?

Rwanda surprised me with how modern and organized it is. The cleanliness of Kigali was not what I expected from stereotypes of Africa. Connecting with local colleagues quickly helped.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

How clean and organized everything is. Kigali rivals any European city in terms of cleanliness and urban planning.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Missing family and friends was hardest. Rwanda is beautiful but small and can feel limiting if you are used to a big city.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

- Home cooked food from my family - Close friends and familiar social environment - Reliable infrastructure and predictability

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

- Safety and cleanliness - The sense of community and warmth of people - The depth of experience and personal growth

Have you had your introductory meeting with your Alumni Mentor?

Yes

How often do you and your mentor check in?

Monthly

The PiAf Fellows Whatsapp Community has helped me build a sense of community with my cohort.

Agree

How often do you engage with the PiAf Fellows Whatsapp Community?

Several times a week

PiAf's Pre-Departure Orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Somewhat Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

The orientation was helpful for general preparation but some country specific information about visas and daily life would have been valuable.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post?

More specific visa guidance for each country would have reduced stress significantly. A country specific guidebook written by past fellows would be extremely helpful.

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office?

Yes, the team has been responsive and supportive throughout.

Programming Ideas

A structured peer mentorship system connecting fellows in similar countries or sectors. More opportunities for fellows to share experiences across the cohort.